
Premier League: 10 talking points from the weekend's football

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Premier League: 10 talking points from the weekend's football

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Life of O'Reilly for City against Salah

Amid the headlines about Phil Foden and Jude Bellingham being recalled for England, there was a little less said about Nico O'Reilly being named in Thomas Tuchel's squad. Myles Lewis-Skelly paid the price for his lack of game time and now the City man gets his opportunity to stake a claim for a World Cup spot. The 20-year-old now goes into camp having become the latest defender to shut out Mohamed Salah. That's less of an achievement than it used to be, but O'Reilly still had to show tenacity and patience against this nuggety, late-era version of the Egyptian superstar. The City full-back nicked the ball off his man regularly – much to the delight of the home fans – and got forward to decent effect, too. If Pep Guardiola trusts O'Reilly in the biggest games and he can avoid injury there is no reason to think that the City academy graduate cannot make England's most open position his own. **Tom Bassam**

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Match report: [Manchester City 3-0 Liverpool](#)

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Elliott absent from Villa's party

After a 4-0 win, presumably it was smiles all round for Aston Villa? It felt that way as Unai Emery and his players departed the pitch after destroying [Bournemouth](#). For Harvey Elliott, though, it was another difficult afternoon. Omitted from the match squad for the third successive league game (though he was ineligible to face his parent club, Liverpool), the 22-year-old last played for Villa on 2 October as an 86th-minute substitute against Feyenoord. His last league appearance came in September, when he was hooked at half-time against his former club Fulham. Emery points to the form of those with whom Elliott is competing, including Emi Buendía and Ross Barkley, both among the scorers on Sunday. Then there is Morgan Rogers, who has evolved into one of Emery's undroppables. Elliott, a deadline-day arrival, has to play at least 10 games to trigger a £35m permanent move from Liverpool but, after just seven matches and 98 top-flight minutes, might he have played his final game for Villa? **Ben Fisher**

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Canvot covers for Guéhi in style

Crystal Palace's reluctance to sell Marc Guéhi to Liverpool in the summer stemmed from Oliver Glasner's concerns that his 19-year-old replacement Jaydee Canvot wasn't experienced enough to cope with the demands of playing in four competitions this season. Gifting a goal to the Cypriot side AEK Larnaca in a Conference League defeat on his first start since a £23m move from Toulouse gave credence to those doubts. In the 0-0 draw with Brighton on Sunday, the France Under-21 international was outstanding as he expertly filled in for the injured Guéhi and didn't put a foot wrong. As Glasner put it, Canvot has "all the hardware that you need as a centre-back – he has pace, he is tall". He also predicted there is more to come as Canvot's confidence grows. "Now it's about giving him time, step by step, helping him to become the best he can be," the Palace manager said. "I can still remember a little bit when I was 19. When you get your debut in the Premier League, you should be delighted and especially you shouldn't have fear." **Ed Aarons**

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Match report: [Crystal Palace 0-0 Brighton](#)

Bees striker succession keeps on rolling

How other clubs must yearn for Brentford's ability to continue procuring goalscorers. Ivan Toney was initially their star frontman and so effective that he played his way into the England reckoning and then over to Saudi Arabia. Yoane Wissa and Bryan Mbeumo took over, scored hatfuls and then departed in big-money moves this summer. How could they possibly cope without their lethal attacking duo? Arise Igor Thiago, whose double against Newcastle took his league tally to eight this season – behind only Erling Haaland in the top goalscorer list. An injury-ravaged first campaign in England has given way to a wonderful second as he now shoulders the club's goalscoring responsibility. "He's just in a great vein of form," the [Brentford](#) manager, Keith Andrews, said. "Playing full of confidence. A huge personality. He's loving life, loving football. Long may it continue." **Ben Bloom**

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Forest must get more from Igor Jesus

Igor Jesus is clearly a very good footballer, but whether he is a [Premier League](#) No 9 is yet to be seen. Sean Dyche gave him an hour against Leeds but the Brazilian was unable to act as the focal point demanded by his head coach. When there are balls to chase, he does his best but gives off the impression of someone who would be more suited to playing deeper. When he joined from Botafogo, he was seen as a nine-and-a-half, but none of the three coaches under whom he has played at Forest in four months in England have considered pairing him with anyone. With Chris Wood injured, Igor Jesus has been given more minutes to acclimatise to the Premier League but is yet to score, his five goals coming in the Carabao Cup and Europa League. If he wants to challenge Wood and Taiwo Awoniyi in the longer term, he will need to adapt his game. **Will Unwin**

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Match report: [Nottingham Forest 3-1 Leeds](#)

Sesko odd man out in United's new trident

The advantage of splashing £200m on three forwards in the summer is that, while it means certain areas of the side still require significant investment, it makes it less obvious if one is struggling. While Bryan Mbeumo is looking increasingly comfortable at [Manchester United](#) – the opening goal at Tottenham was his fourth in four league games – Benjamin Sesko is yet to settle. The Slovenian has scored against Brentford and Sunderland this season but does not seem a natural fit in United's front three. In an era of big centre-forwards whose grace makes it a surprise how tall they are, Sesko is a 6ft 5in striker who looks 6ft 5in. Sent through late on with the score at 1-1, he clanked

into the path of Micky van de Ven's challenge and left the field with a knee injury that was a worry for Ruben Amorim post-match. Perhaps United aren't using the striker in a way that maximises his strengths but he looks way off the level of Mbeumo and Matheus Cunha. **Jonathan Wilson**

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Match report: [Tottenham 2-2 Manchester United](#)

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Older Irons bring fire to flagging side

Both Tomas Soucek and Jarrod Bowen were presented with special shirts to mark 250 appearances for West Ham. Both arrived together in January 2020 and starred in the club's glorious Conference League run in 2023. In West Ham's hour of need, their selflessness will be vital. Bowen, the captain, has assumed the role of penitent frontman for a failing institution. Soucek is happy to be supplanted by young Freddie Potts in midfield. "I can be happy for him and hope he will carry on with his performances," the Czech international said. "Even though I want to be on the pitch as much as possible to help the team in any way, I am happy that I am still a big part of the squad." Against [Burnley](#), a scratchy Bowen did not have one of his better games but Soucek came off the bench to win the match. Following his poacher's goal, it was his shot which led to Kyle Walker-Peters's late clincher. **John Brewin**

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Match report: [West Ham 3-2 Burnley](#)

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Sunderland bridge gap to top flight

Sunderland have made the best start to a Premier League season by a promoted club since Hull City 17 years ago. The 2-2 draw with Arsenal on Saturday means they have taken 19 points from their first 11 games after returning from an eight-year spell outside of the division. The new £31m Keel Crossing, which connects Sunderland's city centre with the Stadium of Light, opened last month and the club are successfully bridging the gap between Championship and Premier League. Sitting in fourth place having taken a point from the leaders, relegation feels like a distant prospect but there is a warning from that Hull campaign: despite starting the 2008-09 season with 20 points from 11 games, Phil Brown's side stayed up by just one point. The [Sunderland](#) slogan for last season's playoff campaign was "Til the End", and that fighting spirit was on show again at the Stadium of Light. "Here at Sunderland, we have many players who will give their life to keep a clean sheet or stop a shot," the manager, Régis Le Bris, said after another famous performance. **Miles Starforth**

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Match report: [Sunderland 2-2 Arsenal](#)

Fernández feeling pain of long season

Enzo Fernández is another player who appears to be suffering from the impact of the Club World Cup. The [Chelsea](#) midfielder, who played a key role in the club's victory in the US last summer, is battling through pain. Fernández was excellent during his side's win against Wolves on Saturday but the Argentinian needs a rest and will not represent his country against Angola this week. "I will not be available with Argentina," Fernández said. "I was just talking to the medical team because I had a problem with my knee in the last four months. I came with a bone edema [swelling] that got worse in the last weeks and months because we played a lot of games. I think the most important thing is coming to the end of the season and I think it's good to make this decision together, always respecting the doctors." **Jacob Steinberg**

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Match report: [Chelsea 3-0 Wolves](#)

Everton duo boost England credentials

David Moyes championed the England cause of James Garner following Everton's comfortable win against Fulham. The [Everton](#) manager reasoned that, with Thomas Tuchel calling up Bournemouth's Alex Scott for the forthcoming World Cup qualifiers, "on Jimmy's form, he can't be a million miles off either". Having been switched to full-back to improve Everton's distribution from the right, Garner did impress. However, the strongest outfield performance from an English-born player came from Kiernan Dewsbury-Hall. The uncapped 27-year-old, who recently pledged his allegiance to England rather than the Republic of Ireland, produced arguably his finest display since his summer move from Chelsea. "He has made us much more creative and cultured in the way we play," Moyes said. "He might be going under the radar a wee bit but he is playing so well. He covers big distances. He is an intelligent boy as well and has certainly helped us play better." **Andy Hunter**

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Match report: [Everton 2-0 Fulham](#)

Pos	Team	P	GD	Pts
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Pos	Team	P	GD	Pts
1	Arsenal	11	15	26
2	Man City	11	15	22
3	Chelsea	11	10	20
4	Sunderland	11	4	19
5	Tottenham Hotspur	11	9	18
6	Aston Villa	11	3	18
7	Man Utd	11	1	18
8	Liverpool	11	1	18
9	AFC Bournemouth	11	-1	18
10	Crystal Palace	11	5	17
11	Brighton	11	2	16
12	Brentford	11	0	16
13	Everton	11	-1	15
14	Newcastle	11	-3	12
15	Fulham	11	-4	11
16	Leeds	11	-10	11
17	Burnley	11	-8	10
18	West Ham	11	-10	10
19	Nottm Forest	11	-10	9
20	Wolverhampton	11	-18	2

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